Team 10 – DineCheck Competitors

Competitor Teardown — UTEP Dining

Competitor: UTEP Dining Website

Type: Direct Competitor / Existing Campus Alternative

Website: https://utepdining.sodexomyway.com/en-us/

Duration: 30 minutes

Conducted by Team 10 on mobile devices; no account is needed for access.

1. Overview

UTEP Dining is a website that provides students with information about dining locations on campus. Students can use it to check operating hours, browse menus, and review nutritional and dietary information.

It is a direct competitor to DineCheck because both aim to help students make decisions about where and what to eat on campus.

2. Features and Observations

During the teardown, we opened the UTEP Dining hours page and selected Pick N' Shovel to explore its dining information.

We changed the menu date and enabled the vegetarian dietary filter. The website accepted the filter selection, but the menu section we reviewed did not provide enough information to determine whether specific food items were currently available. The most recent menu visible was from July, so the posted menu was out of date. The website is free to use.

3. Strengths

- Provides information specifically about UTEP dining locations.
- Displays operating hours for campus dining options.
- Includes menu and nutritional information.
- Offers dietary and allergen filters.
- Combines campus dining information in one website.

4. Limitations and Areas to Investigate

Although the website provides useful information, our review raised questions about how accurately students can determine current food availability.

Areas requiring further investigation include:

- Whether students can identify sold-out menu items.
- Whether the website distinguishes between a dining location being open and its kitchen still serving food.
- Whether students can see when menu availability was last updated.
- Whether students can confirm that a particular meal is available before walking to the location.

These are areas for further testing rather than confirmed missing features.

5. Comparison to DineCheck

UTEP Dining already provides menus, operating hours, and dietary filters, meaning DineCheck cannot treat these features as unique advantages.

DineCheck could potentially differentiate itself by emphasizing current food availability. For example, the proposed application could show whether a dining location is open, whether food is still being served, and whether specific items are available.

This could help students avoid unnecessary trips during short breaks between classes.

6. Conclusion

UTEP Dining provides useful information for students searching for food on campus. However, our walkthrough did not establish whether students can reliably confirm the availability of specific menu items, and the most recent menu we could see was from July.

DineCheck could potentially improve this experience by presenting clearer, more frequently verified availability information.

A visible update time and current menus would address the two problems we found. DineCheck would still need to show that its information stays more current than the official site.

Competitor Teardown 2 — Google Maps

Competitor: Google Maps

Type: Indirect Competitor

Website: https://maps.google.com

Duration: 30 minutes

Conducted by Jacob and Salvador, signed in with a personal Google accounts.

1. Overview

Google Maps is a navigation and location-search application that students can use to find restaurants near UTEP. It provides information such as restaurant locations, operating hours, directions, reviews, and sometimes menus and prices. It is an indirect competitor to DineCheck because students can use it to decide where to eat.

2. Features and Initial Observations

Jacob searched for restaurants near UTEP and opened the listings for Crave Kitchen & Bar and the UTEP Dining Hall.

The listings displayed opening status, hours, address, reviews, directions, and a link to the restaurant's website. Seeing more detailed information about a place required signing in with a Google account.

3. Strengths

- Students can find restaurants near campus.
- Provides directions and estimated travel distances.
- Displays restaurant hours and customer reviews.
- Offers information about different restaurants in one application.

4. Limitations to Investigate

- Whether specific menu items are currently available.
- Whether restaurant menus are updated frequently enough to be reliable.
- Whether students can distinguish between a restaurant being open and its kitchen serving food.

- Whether the application provides enough information to make a quick dining decision between classes.

5. Comparison to DineCheck

Google Maps is useful for finding restaurants and getting directions. However, DineCheck aims to focus specifically on campus dining and potentially provide more detailed information about current food availability. Looking at dining options on campus returned results but did not show menu details.

6. Conclusion

Google Maps is a convenient option for students looking for places to eat. Our teardown shows that it provides location information, directions, and restaurant details.

Neither listing let us confirm that a particular meal was available before traveling, and the campus dining listing showed no menu details at all.

Competitor Teardown 3 — Nutrislice

Competitor: Nutrislice

Type: Direct Competitor

Duration: 30 minutes

Conducted by Team 10 on mobile devices through the Nutrislice iOS app. No login was required, and no pricing was offered; the app is free to use, just location that is compatible is needed.

Location used: University of New Hampshire

1. Overview

Nutrislice is a digital dining platform used by universities to display food menus and nutritional information. It allows students to check dining options, review ingredients, and filter foods based on dietary needs.

Nutrislice is a direct competitor to DineCheck because both focus on helping students find dining information and make decisions about what to eat.

2. Features

During the walkthrough, Nutrislice provided the following features:

- Daily dining menus.
- Food descriptions and nutritional information.
- Dietary and allergen filters.
- Favorite dining locations.
- Menu updates by dining staff through its Sidekick application (from Nutrislice's documentation; not tested by us).

These features overlap with several functions that DineCheck plans to offer.

3. Walkthrough

We first tried the University of New Hampshire's public Nutrislice menu in a browser.

The menu stayed blank in the browser. We then installed the Nutrislice iOS app and selected the University of New Hampshire location, and the menu data loaded immediately.

No login was required and no pricing was offered.

4. Strengths

- Provides detailed nutritional information.
- Includes dietary and allergen filtering options.
- Allows universities to organize dining menus digitally.
- Supports menu updates by dining staff.
- Already offers several features similar to DineCheck.

5. Limitations and Questions to Investigate

- Does Nutrislice clearly indicate when a particular food item is sold out?
- Can students identify when menu information was last updated?
- Can users distinguish between scheduled menu items and currently available food?
- How easy is it to find a specific meal using dietary filters?
- Can students rely on the information when making last-minute dining decisions?

Any of these questions not answered during the walkthrough still require testing. They should not be treated as confirmed weaknesses.

6. Comparison to DineCheck

Nutrislice already provides digital menus, nutritional information, and dietary filters. Because of this, DineCheck cannot claim these features are unique.

One potential way DineCheck could differentiate itself is by making current food availability easier for students to verify.

For example, DineCheck could distinguish between a location being open, a counter serving food, and a specific menu item being available.

However, further testing is required to determine whether Nutrislice already provides similar capabilities.

7. Conclusion

Nutrislice is an established competitor with several features that overlap with DineCheck's proposed functionality. Our research suggests that DineCheck would need to offer more than

digital menus and dietary filters to stand out. Our initial suggestions are easier navigation, simpler use, and a clearer visual design.